

Curriculum Vitae

Kevin B. McGowan

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Education

2006 - 2011	Ph.D. Linguistics, University of Michigan Dissertation: The Role of Socioindexical Expectation in Speech Perception Patrice Speeter Beddor & Steven P. Abney, co-chairs Julie Boland, Benjamin Munson, & Robin Queen, committee members
2007	Linguistic Institute, Stanford University
1996	B.A. Linguistics, University of Michigan

Employment

2021 -	Associate Professor, Department of Linguistics, University of Kentucky
2015 – 2021	Assistant Professor, Department of Linguistics, University of Kentucky
2013 – 2015	Postdoctoral Scholar, Department of Linguistics, Stanford University Meghan Sumner, PI
2011 - 2013	Lecturer, Department of Linguistics, Rice University
1997 - 2007	Webmaster, Web Production & Database Services Team Lead, Information Technology Division, University of Michigan

Professional Experience

2019	Invited Faculty, “Speech Perception”, Linguistic Society of America Summer Institute, University of California, Davis
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2017	Invited Faculty, “Doing phonetics research” and “Eye tracking for linguistics research” Linguistic Society of America Summer Institute, University of Kentucky
2013	Invited Faculty, “Introduction to Praat” Linguistic Society of America Summer Institute, University of Michigan
2007 - 2010	Journal Assistant & Student Board Member, Language Learning Journal, Blackwell Publishing
2009 - 2010	Research Assistant, Professor Pam Beddor, Michigan Phonetics & Phonology Laboratory
2007 - 2008	Research Assistant, Professors Pam Beddor & A. Coetzee, Michigan Phonetics & Phonology Laboratory
1997 - 2007	Programmer &, System administrator, Manager of Web and Database production services, University of Michigan
1993 - 1994	Undergraduate Research Assistant, Professor Richard W. Bailey, Department of English, University of Michigan

Current Projects

- **Dynamic vowel perception, social information, and normalization:** Listeners do not need F1/F2 vowel centers to perceive vowel quality (Strange et al., 1983) or regional identity (Takvoryan and McGowan, in press) in CVC stimuli. In the current phase of this project, we are revisiting empirical demonstrations and models of intrinsic vowel normalization in light of this flexibility of human speech perception to even fairly dramatic reductions in vowel information available to the listener.
- **Gender perception in voices:** A consistent finding in our lab is that the speech percept is comprised of both a linguistic and a social aspect and that these aspects need not agree at any point in processing for perception to succeed. Building upon work from McGowan & Babel (2020) and Laycock & McGowan (2025), our lab is exploring this dual nature of the percept by manipulating both low (e.g. lexical, phonemic) and high (e.g. ideological, regard) aspects of stimuli and testing listener perceptions using an auditory Stroop task.
- **Integration and Assessment of large scale Automatic Speech Recognition in linguistics research:** ASR systems (e.g. HTK, Kaldi) have been essential tools in phonetics and related fields for nearly two decades but forced alignment using these tools still requires time-consuming word-level transcriptions. Semi-supervised ASR systems trained on large scale speech data (e.g. OpenAI’s whisper, Otter.ai) have become useful tools for automatic generation of captions and speech transcription. We are building tutorials and scripts for adding these transcription

tools to established workflows with a particular emphasis on the patterns of errors researchers can expect to encounter and best practices for minimizing the accumulation of errors across the pipeline.

- **Sound change actuation, coarticulation, and regional accent:** Southern US varieties of English differ strikingly from other varieties in their systematic use of vowel internal spectral change (monophthongization of diphthongs, diphthongization or triphthongization of monophthongs). We are pursuing a hypothesis that this dynamism may interact with the perception of nasalized vowels (Beddor & Krakow, 1999) to offer a coarticulatory explanation (Beddor 2009) for why high front lax and mid front lax vowels might be more prone to have merged in these varieties and not others.

Publications

McGowan, K. B., & Takvoryan, S. (in press). The Perception of Linguistic Features. In M. Baranowski, P. De Dekker, & J. Nycz (Eds.), *Oxford Handbook of Research Methods in Sociophonetics*. Oxford University Press.

Takvoryan, S., & McGowan, K. B. (in press). The dynamic, social specification of coarticulated vowels. In R. V. Roeder & G. Alfaraz (Eds.), *Accent, attitudes, and sound change*. Benjamins.

McGowan, K. B. (2026). Toward an ecologically valid theory of speech perception. In L. Hall-Lew & J. Nycz (Eds.), *Sociophonetics: Implications for Phonetics and Phonology*. Oxford University Press.

Namboodiripad, S., Kutlu, E., Babel, A., Babel, M., Baese-Berk, M., Bassuk, P. B., Block, A., Pérez, R. C., Carlson, M. T., Carraturo, S., Cheng, A., Cheng, L. S. P., Combiths, P., Foushee, R., Frederiksen, A. T., Grammon, D., Hayes-Harb, R., Higby, E., Kendro, K., ... Wright, K. E. (2026). Finding our ROLE: How and why to reframe essentialist approaches to language. *Cognition*, 271, 106444. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2026.106444>

Babel, A. M., Campbell-Kibler, K., & McGowan, K. B. (2025). Introduction to the thematic issue. *Journal of Sociolinguistics*, 29(1), 44–58.

Laycock, K., & McGowan, K. B. (2025). Removing the disguise: The matched guise technique, incongruity, and listener awareness. *Journal of Sociolinguistics*, 29(3), 194–209. <https://doi.org/10.1111/josl.12700>

Barrett, R., Cramer, J., & McGowan, K. B. (2022). *English with an accent: Language, ideology, and discrimination in the united states*.

Babel, A., McGowan, K., & Enríquez Duque, P. (2021). Niveles de percepción de las vocales en contacto: El caso de una variedad de español andino en Bolivia. *Traspasando Lo Lingü: Factores Esenciales En El Contacto de Lenguas*-(*Lengua y Sociedad En El Mundo Hispánico*; 48), 119–136.

Medeiros, D. J., Mains, P., & McGowan, K. B. (2021). Ceiling effects on weight in heavy NP shift. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 52(2), 426–440.

Baese-Berk, M. M., McLaughlin, D. J., & McGowan, K. B. (2020). Perception of non-native speech. *Language and Linguistics Compass*, 14(7), e12375.

- McGowan, K. B., & Babel, A. M. (2020). Perceiving isn't believing: Divergence in levels of sociolinguistic awareness. *Language in Society*, 49(2), 231–256.
- McGowan, K. B., Johnson, M. T., Combs, A., & Soleymanpour, M. (2019). Acoustic, non-invasive measurement of velopharyngeal aperture using a high frequency tone. *Proceedings of the 19th International Congress of Phonetic Sciences*, 755–759.
- Beddor, P. S., Coetzee, A. W., Styler, W., McGowan, K. B., & Boland, J. E. (2018). The time course of individuals' perception of coarticulatory information is linked to their production: Implications for sound change. *Language*, 94(4), 931–968.
- McGowan, K. B. (2016). Sounding Chinese and listening Chinese: Awareness and knowledge in the laboratory. *Awareness and Control in Sociolinguistic Research*, 25–61.
- McGowan, K. B. (2015). Social expectation improves speech perception in noise. *Language and Speech*, 58(4), 502–521.
- Sumner, M., Kim, S. K., King, E., & McGowan, K. B. (2014). The socially weighted encoding of spoken words: A dual-route approach to speech perception. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 4, 1015.
- Beddor, P. S., McGowan, K. B., Boland, J. E., Coetzee, A. W., & Brasher, A. (2013). The time course of perception of coarticulation. *The Journal of the Acoustical Society of America*, 133(4), 2350–2366.
- McGowan, K. B. (2011). *The role of socioindexical expectation in speech perception* [PhD thesis]. University of Michigan.
- McGowan, K. B. (2009). Aerodynamic modeling for concatenative speech synthesis. *The Journal of the Acoustical Society of America*, 126(4_Supplement), 2222–2222.

Grants

(submitted)	Dialects of Care: Human-Centered AI Design in Rural Health Contexts Mellon Concepts in Higher Learning with Jennifer Cramer, Dmitry Strakovsky, Chad Eby, and Caleb Williams submitted to
2019 - 2020	Wildcate Voices software development UK Vice President for Research, Research and Creative Activities Grant – \$3,360 with Jennifer Cramer
2018 - 2019	Method and device for acoustic, non-invasive measurement of velopharyngeal aperture using a high frequency tone Igniting Research Collaborations grant, University of Kentucky OVPR, - \$27,726 with Michael Johnson, Electrical and Computer Engineering
2016	Confucius Institute Faculty China Curriculum Development Grant - \$1,000

Advising & Supervision

- Stella Takvoryan (2025) Listening to cursive: The roles of regional identity and folk beliefs in perceptual cue-weighting, MA thesis chair
- Kaitlin Young (2025) Cognate Facilitation and Processing in English-Speaking Learners of German, MA thesis co-chair with Brenna Byrd
- Emily Ramirez (2024) Modeling the Role of Social Information in Speech Perception, UC Berkeley PhD thesis, co-chair with Keith Johnson
- Nour Kayali (2023) "This Make Sense?" The Effect of Congruent Guise in Regional Accent on Grammatical Acceptability Judgments, MA thesis chair
- Jarred Brewster (2021) Language Contact and Covert Prominence in the Šherēt-Jibbāli Language of Oman, MA thesis chair
- Monica Chulde Guayasamin (2021) Face Masks and Speech Perception: Emotions and Intelligibility Perceived by Monolingual and Bilingual Speakers, MA thesis chair
- Kyler Laycock (2021) The Influence of Socioindexical Information on the Speech Perception-Production Link Evidence from a Shadowing Task, MA thesis chair
- Ollie Combs (2020) Relevant Angry Affect Slows Response Time To Commands, MA thesis chair
- Robert Bell (2019) Limón Patwa: A Perceptual Study to Measure Language Attitudes Toward Speakers of Patwa in Costa Rica, MA thesis co-chair
- Andy M Gibson (2019) Sociophonetics of popular music: insights from corpus analysis and speech perception experiments, External Examiner (not advisor)
- Mikhayla Sheeley (2019) Linguistic Relativity and the L2 Learner: An Investigation of the Effects of L2 Grammatical Gender on L1 Conceptual Gender, Undergraduate honors thesis chair
- Jaycee Taylor (2019) Lexington STEAM Academy High School Internship, Supervisor
- Philip Barnett (2018) A Markedly Different Approach: Investigating PIE Stops Using Modern Empirical Methods, MA thesis co-chair with Andrew Byrd
- June Nielsen (2018) Lexington STEAM Academy High School Internship, Supervisor
- Aidah Aljuran (2017) "Listening with an Attitude" The Role of Attitude on Native and Non-Native Intergroup Communication, MA thesis chair
- Kelly E. Wright (2017) The Reflection and Reification of Racialized Language in Popular Media, MA thesis chair
- Kaitlyn Lee (2016) The Perception of Creaky Voice Does Speaker Gender Affect our Judgments?, MA thesis chair
- Jo Mackby (2016) Cries from The Jungle: The Dialogic Linguistic Landscape of the Migrant and Refugee Camps in Calais, France, MA thesis co-chair with Mark Lauersdorf

- Ksenia Gnevsheva (2015) Variation in passing for a native speaker: accentedness in second language speakers of English in production and perception, External Examiner (not advisor)
- John Galindo (2014) A psychoacoustic study of the influence of L1 lexical tone and pitch perception, Rice University, Qualifying Paper, chair
- Penelope Howe (2014) Investigation of cues to fricative voicing in dialects of Malagasy, Rice University, Qualifying Paper, chair
- Hussein Hizazi (2013) Formant Analysis of Jordanian Arabic Vowels: Emphasis Effect on F2 in Jordanian Arabic, Rice University, Qualifying Paper, chair
- Ling Ma (2013) Native Mandarin perception of English word boundary consonant overlap., Rice University, Qualifying Paper, chair
- Mariama Mallah (2013) Directed undergraduate research, Stanford University
- Obi Nwabueze (2013) The use of eye-tracking in speech perception research, Undergraduate Research
- Sheri-Ann Peckham (2013) Investigation of age-related perceptual plasticity using Jamaican Creole, Undergraduate Research

Service to the field

- Language, Conflict, and Peacebuilding ## Selected Software Projects
 - CoSign, Open Source Web Single SignOn (co-founder, developer)
 - ChomskyBot, Pseudo-random Sentence Generator and Gentle Mockery Engine
 - ldapweb, Web-based LDAP Directory Client
 - kpasswd.cgi, Web-based Kerberos password changer

Technologies

- Eyelink II head-mounted eye tracker, EG2-PCX Electroglottograph, EVA 2 pneumotachograph, Zonare Ultrasound, Praat, Wavesurfer, OpenSesame, sox, etc.
- Python, Perl, C, Bourne shell, JavaScript, awk, tcl, SQL, PL/SQL
- RDBMS systems (Oracle, MySQL, PostgreSQL)
- UNIX administration & programming (Linux, OpenBSD, MacOS, Solaris, etc.)
- HTML, XML, CSS, LaTeX, Markdown, Typst

Professional affiliations

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| 2009 - | Acoustical Society of America |
| 2006 - | Linguistic Society of America |